

Raptor Center sells bricks to raise money for building

by Andy Warfield

The Carolina Raptor Center has come up with an unusual way for individuals and businesses to support the center's efforts to care for injured birds of prey.

For \$35 each, individuals and companies can have their name and/or message etched in a brick to be used in a walkway or the courtyard at the entrance to the new center being built at Latta Plantation Park.

"The appealing thing about this is a lot of people know about the Raptor Center and they're willing to donate, and those who give in this way really get something in return," says Raptor Center board member David Hains. "Their name is going to be there for many years, so it serves as a memorial for loved ones, or even their own name."

Each brick can contain up to 17 characters, including spaces, on three lines. Raptor Center Executive Director Pat Marcum says some individuals and companies have bought several to be placed side-by-side to present lengthier messages than a single brick can accommodate.

The Raptor Center's goal is to sell 2,000 imprinted bricks, about one-fourth of the 8,000 needed for the walkway from the parking lot and the courtyard. But with the potential for miles of walking trails over the center's 57 wooded acres at Latta Plantation Park, the imprinted bricks can be sold indefinitely, if desired.

At any given time, the 10-year-old Raptor Center plays host to 150 to 200 birds of prey — owls, hawks, eagles and vultures. Thus far, they have been given medical attention in a single-wide mobile home structure, and the center's office has been located in a second trailer. A gift shop is located in a permanent building.

The construction of the new building, which will house the center's offices, classrooms, exhibits and an amphitheater, is about three years ahead of schedule. That is in large part thanks to the generosity of members Fred and Edna Moretti, who agreed to give \$100,000 toward the project if the center could raise the addi-



Individuals can have their name or message etched in a brick at the Carolina Raptor Center for \$35. Funds raised through brick sales will go toward program support. Perched atop the brick is Serena, an owl that is used for teaching at the center. Photo by M.J. Masotti Jr.

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tional \$121,000 necessary.

This, however, threw the organization into its first capital campaign. A \$40,000 grant from Mecklenburg County has given the campaign a boost, but more money is still needed.

"Because we had a short time to raise the rest of the money and because the operating base is important to us, we didn't want to ask the members to fund

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